LONDON AND OTHER LOCATIONS, UNITED KINGDOM

# Tate: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which precision, atmosphere and distortion give different forms to experience.



The plants around Millais’s Ophelia remain insistently detailed while a body floats among them. In Turner’s storm, the difficulty is almost reversed: the surroundings make the boat hard to locate. Neither method is simply more realistic than the other. One keeps the visible world sharply available at a moment of death; the other lets weather disrupt the act of seeing itself.

This selection follows that contrast through literary subjects, city scenes and invented bodies. Some images become denser the longer they are examined. Others depend on the few details they allow to survive. The difference offers a more useful starting point than treating all looseness as spontaneity or all precision as certainty.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

## Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context  Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/tate

# The selection · 20

1. Ophelia
   John Everett Millais · 1851–2
2. The Lady of Shalott
   John William Waterhouse · 1888
3. The Awakening Conscience
   William Holman Hunt · 1853
4. Carnation, Lily, Lily, Rose
   John Singer Sargent · 1885–6
5. Peace: Burial at Sea
   J. M. W. Turner · exhibited 1842
6. Norham Castle, Sunrise
   J. M. W. Turner · c.1845
7. Snow Storm: Steam-Boat off a Harbour's Mouth
   J. M. W. Turner · 1842
8. Beata Beatrix
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · c.1864–70
9. The Mud Bath
   David Bomberg · 1914
10. The Fairy Feller's Master-Stroke
    Richard Dadd · 1855–64
11. The Ghost of a Flea
    William Blake · c.1819–20
12. Nocturne: Blue and Gold—Old Battersea Bridge
    James Abbott McNeill Whistler · c.1872–5
13. Industrial Landscape
    L.S. Lowry · 1955
14. Three Studies for Figures at the Base of a Crucifixion
    Francis Bacon · c.1944
15. Hampstead Heath with a Rainbow
    John Constable · 1836
16. Self-Portrait with Badges
    Peter Blake · 1961
17. The Disrobing of Christ
    Sir Stanley Spencer · 1922
18. Bursting Shell
    Christopher Richard Wynne Nevinson · 1915
19. Dorelia in a Black Dress
    Gwen John · c.1903–4
20. Farms near Auvers
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890

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# Ophelia

John Everett Millais

1851–2 · Oil on canvas · Tate



John Everett Millais. Ophelia. Image credit: John Everett Millais. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Ophelia's open hands and floating body occupy a stream whose vegetation is described with sustained attention. The setting does not fall out of focus around the human event. That equality of detail creates a difficult relation: the plants continue to claim the eye while the figure gives the same surroundings a fatal significance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01506

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# The Lady of Shalott

John William Waterhouse

1888 · Oil on canvas · Tate



John William Waterhouse. The Lady of Shalott. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The chain still connects the boat to the bank. Candles, patterned textile and the woman’s white dress make the departure materially specific, while her lifted face directs attention beyond the immediate action. Waterhouse holds the scene close to leaving. The consequences named by the literary subject have not yet been shown.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01543

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# The Awakening Conscience

William Holman Hunt

1853 · Oil on canvas · Tate



William Holman Hunt. The Awakening Conscience. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The woman begins to rise, changing the relation between two bodies in a densely furnished room. The mirror offers another kind of opening, toward a garden and outdoor light. Hunt places the narrative turn in that small adjustment of posture, allowing an enclosing interior and a possible direction beyond it to coexist.

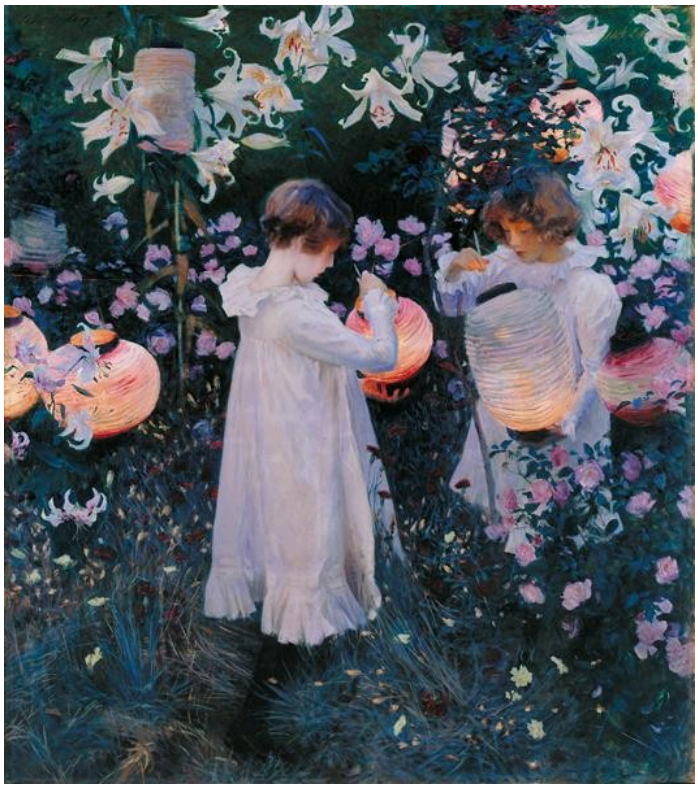
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: T02075

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# Carnation, Lily, Lily, Rose

John Singer Sargent

1885–6 · Oil on canvas · Tate



John Singer Sargent. Carnation, Lily, Lily, Rose. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Warm lantern light has only a limited reach within the cooler garden. The children's pale dresses and surrounding flowers must belong to both that localised glow and the remaining daylight. Sargent gives the scene its particular difficulty by keeping the two forms of illumination present rather than allowing one to cancel the other.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01615

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# Peace: Burial at Sea

J. M. W. Turner

exhibited 1842 · Oil on canvas · Tate



J.M.W. Turner. Peace - Burial at Sea. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The dark sails supply weight within an atmosphere otherwise tending toward dissolution. The painting commemorates the burial at sea of Turner's fellow painter David Wilkie, and was exhibited in 1842. That context gives the blacks a particular task: mourning is concentrated in the vessels' appearance rather than described through a clearly legible funeral ceremony.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Norham Castle, Sunrise

J. M. W. Turner

c.1845 · Oil on canvas · Tate



J. M. W. Turner. Norham Castle, Sunrise. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Castle, low ground and river remain recognisable with few firm edges. This unfinished painting permits light blue and yellow areas to carry relationships that detailed architecture might otherwise explain. It is useful to distinguish that surviving state from a theory of what Turner intended every passage to become: the present surface is what can be examined.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01981

07 / 20

# Snow Storm: Steam-Boat off a Harbour’s Mouth

J. M. W. Turner

1842 · Tate



J. M. W. Turner. Snow Storm - Steamboat off a Harbour's Mouth. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The vessel is hard to secure within the circling marks. Sea and sky cease to provide the stable division expected in a conventional maritime view. Turner makes locating the boat part of the picture’s difficulty. The storm is described through that disruption as much as through any individually identifiable wave.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Beata Beatrix

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

c.1864–70 · Oil on canvas · Tate



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. Beata Beatrix. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Closed eyes and still hands interrupt the ordinary exchange between a depicted figure and the spectator. A red bird approaches, while the warmer space behind remains less distinct. The inward state is presented through signs around the body; it is not literally opened for inspection or reducible to a single visible thought.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01279

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# The Mud Bath

David Bomberg

1914 · Oil on canvas · Tate



David Bomberg. The Mud Bath. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Angular blue and white forms cross the red field, retaining suggestions of bodies without continuous anatomy. The group's action survives in directions and intersections rather than individual faces. Bomberg gives a bodily subject a different scale of recognition: first a collective arrangement, then fragments from which figures may be recovered.

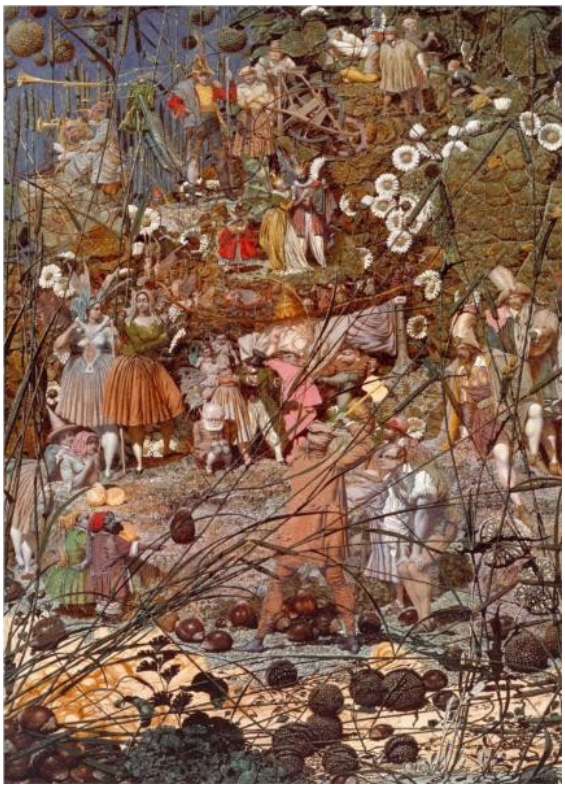
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: T00656

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# The Fairy Feller’s Master-Stroke

Richard Dadd

1855–64 · Oil on canvas · Tate



Richard Dadd. The Fairy Feller’s Master-Stroke. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The woodcutter occupies a society so densely populated that the surrounding witnesses compete with the central action. Grasses, leaves and tiny figures overlap within shallow space. Dadd’s detail does not make the whole instantly clear. It divides attention into repeated encounters, each of which reveals how much remains outside the current focus.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: T00598

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# The Ghost of a Flea

William Blake

c.1819–20 · Tempera and gold on mahogany · Tate



William Blake. The Ghost of a Flea. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The creature has muscular weight and a walking stance, though its partly animal body refuses an ordinary human identity. Curtains give the movement a staged setting, and the carried vessel supplies a small action. Blake’s invention depends on recognisable anatomy: the departures become more definite because enough familiar structure remains.

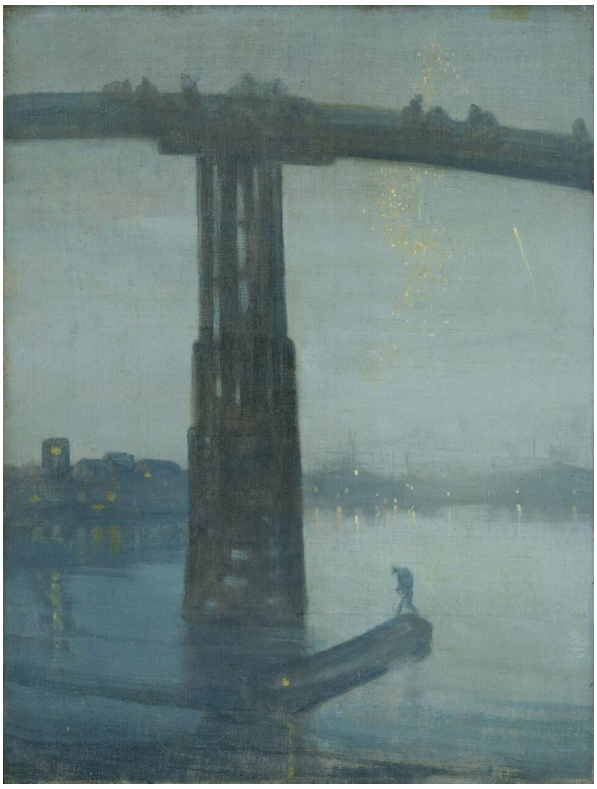
Object source · Open artwork

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# Nocturne: Blue and Gold—Old Battersea Bridge

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

c.1872–5 · Oil on canvas · Tate



James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Nocturne: Blue and Gold - Old Battersea Bridge. Image credit: James McNeill Whistler; Source credit: The Yorck Project (2002) 10.000 Meisterwerke der Malerei (DVD-ROM), distributed by DIRECTMEDIA Publishing GmbH. ISBN : 3936122202 .. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The bridge is a large, dark shape over water whose distances are supplied by sparse lights and a small boat. Blue and gold connect elements that are not equally described. Whistler makes the setting legible with few anchors, allowing the withheld detail to remain part of the night rather than something the spectator must complete.

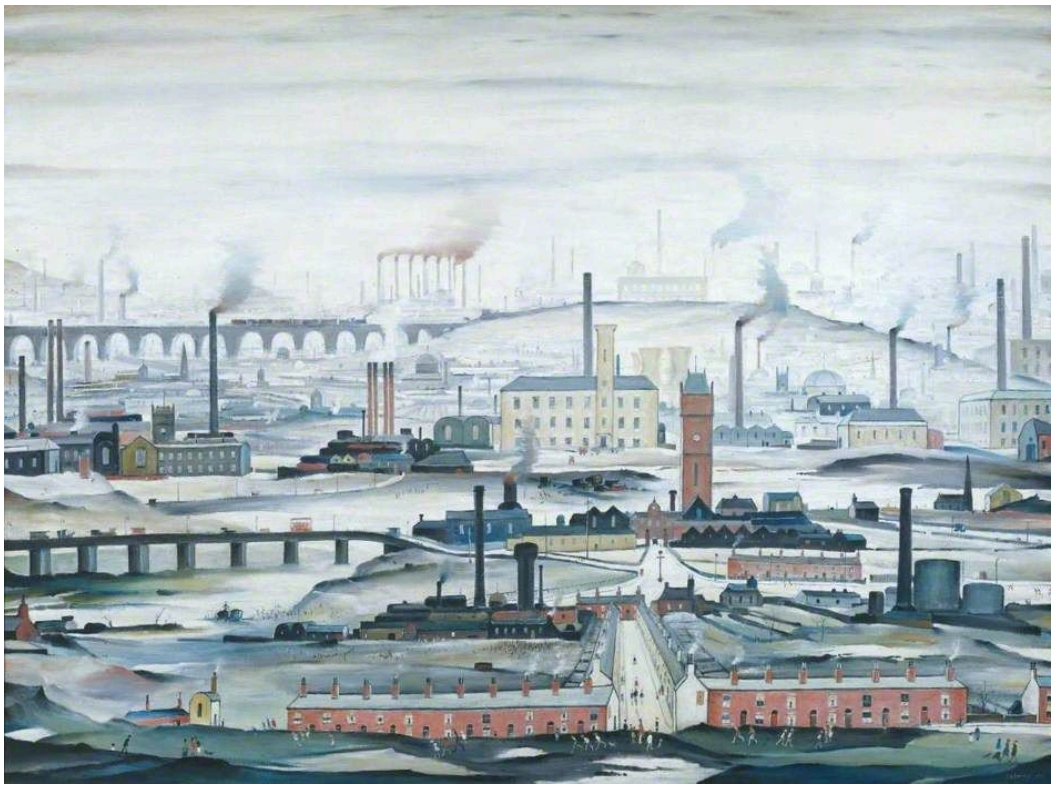
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01959

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# Industrial Landscape

L.S. Lowry

1955 · Oil on canvas · Tate



L.S. Lowry. Industrial Landscape. WikiArt source label: L. S. Lowry Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/l-s-lowry/industrial-landscape-1955 · L. S. Lowry Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Chimneys and buildings continue far beyond any one workplace. Small figures establish a human scale within their repetition, while roads connect one part of the built environment to another. Lowry treats industry as a place people inhabit, not merely a collection of machines or a single factory seen from outside.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: T00111

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# Three Studies for Figures at the Base of a Crucifixion

Francis Bacon

c.1944 · Oil on 3 boards · Tate



Francis Bacon. Three Studies for Figures at the Base of a Crucifixion. WikiArt source label: Francis Bacon Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francis-bacon/three-studies-for-figures-at-the-base-of-a-crucifixion-1944 · Francis Bacon Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The three panels give the creatures separate spaces but comparable orange grounds. Long necks, mouths and supports retain enough bodily information for distortion to register clearly. They share no continuous room and need not be forced into one sequential event. Repetition establishes their relation while leaving their individual predicaments distinct.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

# Hampstead Heath with a Rainbow

John Constable

1836 · Oil on canvas · Tate



John Constable. Hampstead Heath with a Rainbow. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The rainbow’s clear curve crosses a sky that otherwise breaks into unstable cloud and darkness. Light singles out parts of the heath below without illuminating it evenly. Constable connects separate areas through the brief arc, making weather an active redistribution of the landscape’s visibility rather than a background condition.

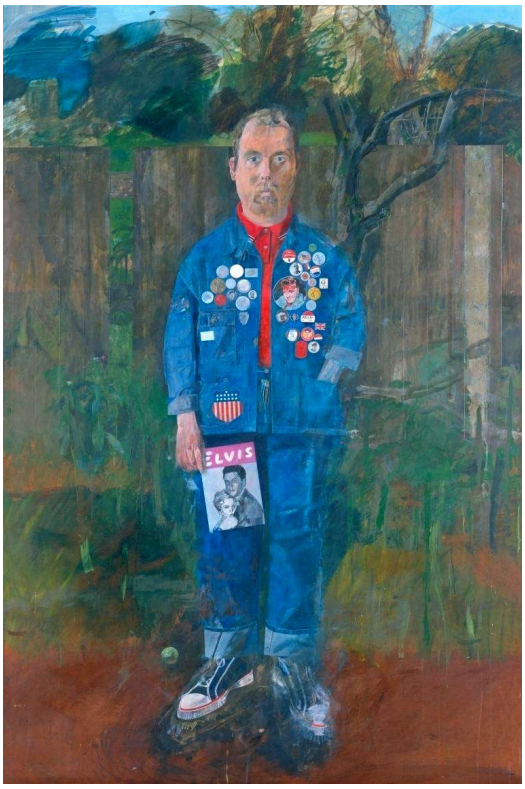
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N01275

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# Self-Portrait with Badges

Peter Blake

1961 · Oil on board · Tate




Peter Blake. Self-Portrait with Badges. WikiArt source label: Peter Blake Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/peter-blake/self-portrait-with-badges-1961 · Peter Blake Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The badges make selected images part of the figure's outward appearance. They interrupt the jacket while contributing to the self-portrait's account of identity. Face and stance remain important, but likeness is not the sole evidence. What a person wears and displays can occupy the same pictorial space as the features they were born with.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: T02406

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# The Disrobing of Christ

Sir Stanley Spencer

1922 · Oil on wood · Tate



The Disrobing of Christ. WikiArt; WikiArt. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Public domain US

The removal of cloth requires several bodies to act in a cramped, angular space. The nearly naked figure is exposed through their handling rather than presented in isolation. Spencer keeps the sacred episode attached to awkward physical relations: fabric can conceal, connect and resist the people pulling at it.

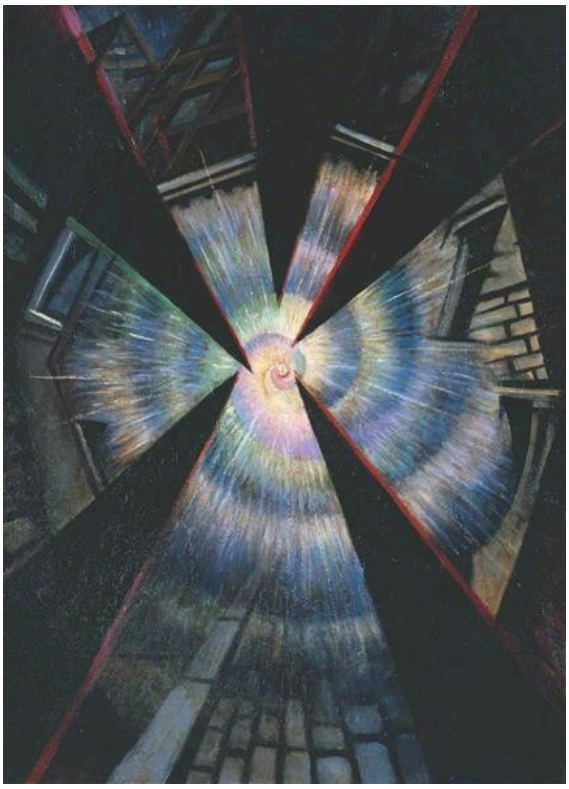
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N04926

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# Bursting Shell

Christopher Richard Wynne Nevinson

1915 · Oil on canvas · Tate



Christopher Richard Wynne Nevinson. Bursting Shell. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The explosion has no comfortably distant position from which to be watched. Wedges and lines radiate through the entire arrangement, carrying its force beyond a single depicted object. Nevinson gives violence a directional structure. The absence of a detailed injured body does not make the event remote when the space itself breaks apart.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: T03676

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# Dorelia in a Black Dress

Gwen John

c.1903–4 · Oil on canvas · Tate



Gwen John. Dorelia in a Black Dress. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The loosely crossed arms keep the standing pose composed without locking it into rigid symmetry. A pink accent and small changes of light distinguish the figure within a restricted range of colour. Gwen John allows the plain wall to remain plain, concentrating the encounter on face, hands and the slight adjustments of posture.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Farms near Auvers

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · Tate



Vincent van Gogh. Farms near Auvers. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: 1. vangoghgallery.com 2. Tate Online , image. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Thatched roofs, trees, walls and sloping ground receive marks moving in different directions. The surface stays active without making every material identical. The crowded buildings can be followed through those changes, demonstrating how a landscape may remain legible even when hardly any part of the paint settles into an uninterrupted field.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: N04713

# Distinguish a difficult image from an unclear text

Dadd’s density and Turner’s disrupted visibility need different kinds of looking; neither needs vague praise in place of description. Compare what each lets remain clear. Tate is a collection presented across venues and changing displays, so check each work’s current location before planning a visit.

# Further reading

## The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

Ruskin’s exercises in looking at natural forms offer a useful companion to the Pre-Raphaelite paintings. His attention to edges and light also gives a starting point for discussing why Turner’s surfaces are harder to separate into objects.

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Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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